



DEPARTMENT OF THE AIR FORCE  
DEAN OF FACULTY  
UNITED STATES AIR FORCE ACADEMY

5 January 2026

MEMORANDUM FOR DF FACULTY AND STAFF, AND CADET WING

FROM: HQ USAFA DF/CC

SUBJECT: Generative AI Usage Policy Memo, Academic Year 2025-2026 (Spring 2026)

1. To promote consistency, transparency, and academic integrity across our academic programs, the Dean of Faculty is establishing standardized expectations and language for the use of generative artificial intelligence (GenAI) in academic contexts. Without such consistency, differences across courses may lead to confusion and unintentional violations of academic standards. This policy applies to all cadets and faculty and will be adopted across all courses and academic disciplines. Traditional spellcheck and grammar check tools (e.g., those built into word processors) are not considered GenAI for the purposes of this policy.
2. The attached Guidance for Academic GenAI Usage outlines a framework of seven levels of GenAI usage and serves as the official policy describing the communication of permissible GenAI use in academic courses. Instructors are required to designate the GenAI usage level(s) (0–6) for each assignment or for their course overall using the attached framework. Instructors may further tailor GenAI expectations for specific assignments (e.g., which GenAI to use), but must clearly communicate those expectations to cadets. Higher-numbered levels automatically permit the use defined in all lower-numbered levels unless otherwise specified.
3. Cadets are expected to document their GenAI use similar to other source citations, with specific instructions provided by instructors. In most cases, a full transcript of any GenAI interactions for course assignments should be retained until final grades are submitted. Attempting to submit GenAI-generated content as original work without proper documentation constitutes a violation of academic integrity.
5. Through this guidance, we support our commitment to academic excellence, ethical leadership, and the responsible integration of emerging technologies. GenAI presents an opportunity to enhance learning, spark innovation, and prepare cadets for the dynamic challenges they will face as officers in the Air Force and Space Force. When used thoughtfully and transparently, it can deepen understanding, improve efficiency, and cultivate the intellectual agility essential to our profession. Together, we will model and uphold the standards that distinguish a USAFA education—developing leaders of character equipped to thrive in an AI-enabled world!

A handwritten signature in black ink, reading "S. C. M. Hasstedt", is positioned above the name of the Acting Dean of the Faculty.

STEVEN C. M. HASSTEDT, Colonel, USAF  
Acting Dean of the Faculty

Attachment:  
Guidance for Academic GenAI Usage (Spring 2026)

## Guidance for Academic-GenAI Usage (Spring 2026)

Generative AI (GenAI) tools are readily available and can provide support for both instructors and cadets, better enabling them to innovate and improve efficiency. However, inappropriate use of GenAI may reduce learning, and AI products may incorporate errors due to “hallucinations” and bias resulting from the datasets used to train the GenAI. Thus, both cadets and faculty can benefit from clear statements regarding expectations and best practices related to GenAI use, how to verify and document such use, and how to ethically use GenAI.

For purposes of this document, traditional spellcheck and grammar check tools are not considered to be GenAI. They use fixed dictionaries and grammar rules to identify localized problems and offer suggested fixes to those problems; however, they do not provide the larger-scale sentence rewriting that is possible with GenAI. Unless otherwise noted by an instructor, these non-GenAI tools are permissible and not considered to be part of the levels of use described below.

**The following seven levels provide a framework for how AI might be employed in various contexts; these levels can be used at the individual assignment level, at the course level, or more broadly.** Regardless of level of GenAI use, it is the user’s responsibility to verify the accuracy of the results and document level of use. Note that providing transcripts typically requires logging into an account.

### ***Seven Levels of Possible GenAI Usage\****

*Higher levels authorize permission for all lower levels unless otherwise stated by the instructor. Specific examples for each level are provided below the table.*

|                | Level descriptor                                          | What this looks like in practice:                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Level 0</b> | No use of GenAI                                           | Cadets will create their own, original work without the use of GenAI in any manner.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| <b>Level 1</b> | Organizational / Explanatory use of GenAI                 | The use of GenAI for personal efficiency (i.e., summarizing notes / readings, clarifying content) is acceptable; however, cadets will create their own, original work without the use of GenAI for submitted assignments. <i>If later used to support an assignment, this use should be acknowledged in documentation statements.</i>                                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Level 2</b> | Use of GenAI for brainstorming or idea generation         | Cadets may consult GenAI as a tool for initial brainstorming or idea generation, but are expected to create their own, original work without the use of GenAI. <i>Use of GenAI in this manner should be acknowledged as part of documentation statements as described by the instructor.</i>                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>Level 3</b> | Use of GenAI as a feedback tool on student-generated work | Cadets create their own work independently, then may use GenAI as a tool to get feedback about their work (similar to what an instructor might give, e.g., suggestions for improvement, clarification, alignment with the assignment instructions, or editing tips). Cadets are expected to make their own revisions based on this feedback. <i>The cadet should document how and where GenAI was used in their process, potentially including prompts and full transcripts as instructed.</i> |

|                |                                              |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|----------------|----------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Level 4</b> | Use of GenAI to co-create and/or revise work | Cadets may use GenAI to develop drafts, outlines, or provide suggested revisions to their drafts, but they must critically evaluate, revise, and take ownership of the content. Submitted work should reflect the cadet's understanding, not unedited AI output. <i>This use of GenAI must be clearly documented as instructed, specifying how GenAI contributed and what the cadet did to revise or evaluate that content.</i> |
| <b>Level 5</b> | Unrestricted, attributed use of GenAI        | Cadets may submit work that includes unedited or heavily AI-generated content. The emphasis is on transparency, not authorship. <i>The extent and nature of GenAI use must be clearly disclosed with proper attribution in a documentation statement as described by the instructor.</i>                                                                                                                                        |
| <b>Level 6</b> | Unrestricted, unattributed use of GenAI      | While it is possible to use GenAI in an unrestricted manner without attribution, any who apply this level in their course should carefully consider ethical and legal implications.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |

\* These suggested levels were modified from those adopted at Illinois State University.

***Examples of each level of possible GenAI use:***

- **Level 0 (No use):** Cadets will work using source documents, texts, and other materials provided or permitted by the instructor. They should not utilize web searches because GenAI now provides automatic summaries when browsers are queried.
- **Level 1 (Organizational/Explanatory Use):** A cadet asks GenAI to create a study guide or flashcards or Quizlet questions for the major terms in a reading assignment, and then provides the list of terms to GenAI. OR, A cadet asks GenAI to explain a concept they are confused about, and then provides the GenAI with the topic/concept about which they are confused.
- **Level 2 (Idea Generation Use):** A cadet provides GenAI with the instructions for a final project in an applied statistics course where they have to learn a new method and apply it to a dataset. The cadet then asks GenAI to help generate a few ideas for methods to learn, based on a list of their interests so far in the course. OR, A cadet asks GenAI to list some possible angles the cadet could take for a policy memo on reducing energy consumption in military housing. The cadet documents how and where GenAI was used in their process, potentially including prompts and full transcripts as instructed.
- **Level 3 (Feedback Tool Use):** A cadet writes an essay, asks GenAI for feedback on clarity and structure, and then makes their own edits based on the suggestions. OR, A cadet writes some code and then asks GenAI to point out areas where the code could be streamlined; the cadet then focuses on those areas and determines how to make the revisions to improve the code. The cadet documents how and where GenAI was used in their process, potentially including prompts and full transcripts as instructed.
- **Level 4 (Co-create Use):** A cadet is assigned to write a policy memo. They ask GenAI to generate an initial draft based on a prompt they provide, then review the AI-generated content, identify inaccuracies, rewrite large portions, and revise the structure to meet assignment criteria. The final submission reflects the cadet's own reasoning, edits, and understanding—not a direct copy of the AI output. The cadet documents how and where GenAI was used in their process, potentially including prompts and full transcripts as instructed.

- **Level 4 (Revision Suggestions Use):** A cadet writes a full draft of a leadership reflection essay. Before submitting it, they paste the draft into GenAI and ask for suggestions to improve clarity and structure of the essay. GenAI provides several suggestions, including reordering paragraphs and rephrasing unclear sentences. The cadet reviews each suggestion, accepts some, rewrites others in their own words, and rejects the rest. The final submission reflects the cadet's voice and understanding, not the AI's. The cadet documents how and where GenAI was used in their process, potentially including prompts and full transcripts as instructed.
- **Level 5 (Creation by GenAI Use):** A cadet uses GenAI to generate full paragraphs for a literature review and includes the paragraphs in their paper with minimal revision. The cadet adds a footnote and clearly documents how and where AI was used based on the course requirements. OR, A cadet uses GenAI to write most of the R code for a statistics project, or asks GenAI to generate all visuals for a final project presentation. The cadet documents how and where GenAI was used in their process, potentially including prompts and full transcripts as instructed.
- **Mixed level assignment:** The first step of a multi-step project incorporates a brainstorming stage for which cadets are allowed to use GenAI to help come up with initial ideas (Level 2). They are allowed to use GenAI to provide feedback on their first draft but they should not use GenAI to generate any parts of that draft (Level 3). They also engage in peer feedback on the first drafts during which they should not use GenAI at all (Level 0). They apply feedback from GenAI and peers to write their final version for grading with no additional use of GenAI (Level 3 continued).
- **Mixed level course:** An instructor might set the default course level to Level 1, allowing cadets to use GenAI to explain concepts that confuse them or to create podcasts that overview the readings. However, the instructor might also create an assignment with primary source readings that they want cadets to learn to read and interpret on their own, and thus, that assignment would be labeled Level 0.

***Instructor Tailoring of Expectations:*** After clearly communicating the expected GenAI usage level for an assignment or course at large using the above level descriptions, instructors have autonomy to further refine their GenAI expectations for their course or assignment (e.g., by communicating specific GenAI tools to use or specific ways to document GenAI use). When determining their tailored GenAI usage levels, instructors might distinctly consider and communicate its accepted use in background versus foreground tasks. **Foreground tasks are those cadets submit for evaluation** and grading: papers, tests, quizzes, lab reports, presentations, models, etc. Background tasks include those things that cadets do as prep work for the foreground tasks: reading, note-taking, reviewing, studying, researching, etc.

***Cadet Documentation Statements:*** As they do with other sources, cadets should document their use of GenAI. Common best practices include requirements to identify which GenAI tool was used, the transcript showing the specific prompts used and the resultant outputs, and an explanation of how the GenAI output was evaluated, revised, and incorporated into the final product. Additionally, it is good practice to archive these transcripts at least until grades have been submitted in case there are later any questions. Furthermore, it is recommended for instructors to clearly state in their course policies how they will handle insufficient documentation of GenAI use.

- **Example statement on an assignment for cadets:** You will be asked to provide an explanation and reflection of how GenAIs were used on various assignments in this course. Be certain to document this tool as you would any other additional resource, and NEVER attempt to pass off someone or something else's work as your own. Your documentation statement should include 1) what you provided the GenAI and an explanation of your prompts, 2) what the GenAI provided you and an explanation of the output, and 3) how you altered the GenAI's output (e.g., how you iterated on prompts or how you edited the response before using it). A full transcript of your interaction with the GenAI should be provided whenever possible.

**AI Detectors:** While AI detection tools exist, they are imperfect and inconsistent, often generating false positives, especially for non-native English writers and for short texts or hybrid writing. These tools haven't been able to keep pace with GenAI development and should **not** be used as sole evidence for academic misconduct.

**Responsible Use of GenAI by Instructors:** Responsible use of GenAI helps ensure academic integrity, fosters genuine learning, protects privacy, and models ethical use of technology—essential for cadet development and future leadership. Faculty play a key role in guiding and modeling this behavior.

- **Respect student privacy and copyrights.** Many GenAI tools retain user inputs and use inputs to further train that AI tool, potentially making those inputs publicly available. Thus, avoid submitting cadet names, grades, or personal content to public AI tools. Also avoid uploading copyrighted materials or materials that would typically only be accessible behind a pay-wall. When possible, use tools that protect data or allow you to opt out of training models on your input. These options are most often available only through organizational accounts (e.g., USAFA license for Microsoft Copilot) or through the paid versions of the GenAIs. When necessary, consider DOD-sponsored GenAI, (e.g., NIPRGPT), which provides secure data protection.
- **Model transparency.** If you use GenAI to support your teaching—such as drafting assignments, grading, or giving feedback—consider letting your cadets know how you use the tool while still maintaining your professional responsibilities (i.e., AI hasn't replaced their instructor). It can build trust and help them see how professionals use AI responsibly.
- **Use GenAI fairly.** If AI is part of how you assess cadet work, apply it consistently.
- **Clearly communicate expectations.** Ensure that your course policy on GenAI use is clearly stated in your course policies and individual assignments. Make sure that cadets know to ask questions when expectations are unclear and be open to feedback as you develop in your use of GenAI in your course.
- **Set clear guardrails on tools.** Not all GenAI tools are equal in output quality, safety, or cost. Make sure cadets understand the benefits and limitations of the tools they're using. If you plan to require GenAI use, consider having all cadets use the same tool to level the playing field. Whenever possible, design assignments that are tool-agnostic or achievable using free versions to keep the focus on learning, not access.
- **Keep learning at the center.** GenAI should support—not replace—cadet learning. Avoid using it in ways that weaken critical thinking, writing, or problem-solving. Use it when it helps cadets engage more deeply with the material.

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Practical guidance and additional resources will become available through the USAFA Center for Teaching and Learning and on the [McDermott Library GenAI webpage](#).